

Championships. I made a lot of finals and semis. I'd won the Australian Open just a month before. I was the second-seeded player at the Olympics. I was sure I would do better than the last time when I won bronze.

The doctor told me to take 3-4 days' rest and then assess it. But I had to travel to Rio as well. I took cortisone injections to lower the pain, and we taped the knee up tightly, but I knew in practice itself that there was something very wrong with my knee. I was constantly thinking about the pain. I don't even know how I played the two matches that I did.

I got my first surgery when I returned from the Olympics. I did win tournaments after I recovered from the surgery – the Malaysia Open, Denmark Open finals, the Indonesia Open and an Asian Games bronze – but I knew that I was not going to be the same as before.

Later, P.V. Sindhu followed you, but you were the first woman to do all that.

Being the first one to do all that was very hard. If we had had a World Champion before me, it would have been a little bit easier. A lot of the building blocks for Indian badminton weren't in place when I started. These days, players get physios and strength and conditioning experts when they are nine. I got them for the first time when I was 18. If all these things had been pre-planned, there would have been even better results.

Sindhu is also not in the peak days of her career anymore.

I think even with Sindhu, we just take it for granted that she will always be there. She's about 30. 30-31 is still a good age to play. If you are continuing to push after that, you need to have really good trainers and physios. I think she can still play and push herself.

What is the perspective you think people don't really have about your career?

It's not just me, but Sindhu as well. I



think what people will realise, after my career and eventually Sindhu's, is the value of what we achieved. People would just think that these results are coming, but they should realise that this wasn't easy. You need to have a combination of a tough body, dedication, strength and power. You need to have the package of all of that to get results.

We were winning the Super Series every year, and it was taken for granted that we would win them.

Sometimes a player might have the right strokes, but the body doesn't have that kind of power. Sometimes the power is there, but the strokes are not. There are very few players now who have that complete package. But that's not just true in India. I think Malaysia had an all-round player like Lee Chong Wei, but I don't think anyone has come to that level after him. It's the same thing for China after Lin Dan. Among the men, they at least have Shi Yuqi, but among the women, they are a bit up and down.

You had a Sachin (Tendulkar) in cricket, and after that, you had a Virat (Kohli) and a Rohit (Sharma). But in my case, there wasn't any example. I remember the first time I talked about winning an Olympic medal, and my mother laughed. She

Trailblazers in frame: Saina Nehwal and P.V. Sindhu, the twin pillars of India's women's singles rise. PTI

said, 'She is talking about the Olympics when at every tournament it's China who is winning'. You had to be exceptional, I think, then. At first, I didn't believe I could be like one of those Chinese girls, but when I started winning, I began to think that maybe there was something exceptional in me.

In a way, I think the system wasn't ready for someone like me. I was lucky I got a lot of sponsors early in my career, but I didn't have a proper physio until I was 18. Today's kids have a lot more knowledge than me. It was only after I won the Olympic medal that I got to understand how important nutrition is. Sometimes I think it's a miracle that I even reached where I did with so little knowledge.

Why do you think we aren't getting the results, especially in women's singles?

I think about this as well. Maybe it's just part of that up-down cycle. I can't say that today's girls are not good, but something is missing. There's one argument that maybe they need